

QGA, Tarrasch, Chigorin, Albin and Rare 1...d5

One dependable answer to every non-QGD branch after 1.d4 d5 2.c4

THE PROMISE

Take the surprise value out of Black's early captures, counterstrikes, and offbeat development without over-investing study time.

COURSE VOLUME 04 OF 10

SEE THE POSITION | RECALL THE PLAN | CALCULATE THE MOVE

What this volume should change

- Recover the Queen's Gambit Accepted pawn through development and central control.
- Play against the Tarrasch and Semi-Tarrasch isolated-pawn structures with the correct balance of blockade and activity.
- Meet the Chigorin and Albin with concrete, safe move orders.
- Carry a concise answer to Baltic, Marshall, and other rare 1...d5 systems.

STUDY METHOD

Learn each chapter in three layers: first the trigger and plan, then the short main line, then Black's branches. Hide the page and reconstruct the line on a board. Do not memorize notation without the position's purpose.

Inside this volume

01	Queen's Gambit Accepted spine
02	QGA queenside expansion
03	QGA with early ...c5 or ...Bg4
04	Tarrasch Defense
05	Semi-Tarrasch and knight recapture
06	Chigorin Defense
07	Albin Countergambit
08	Baltic, Marshall, and other early deviations

Original instructional synthesis. Move sequences were legality-checked with python-chess and critical choices were reviewed with Stockfish 18. Opening-frequency context was checked against the Lichess opening explorer in September 2026. Engines verify tactics; the explanations and training design are the course's teaching layer. Diagrams use Colin M. L. Burnett's Cburnett piece artwork as distributed by Lichess under GPLv2+.

CHAPTER 01

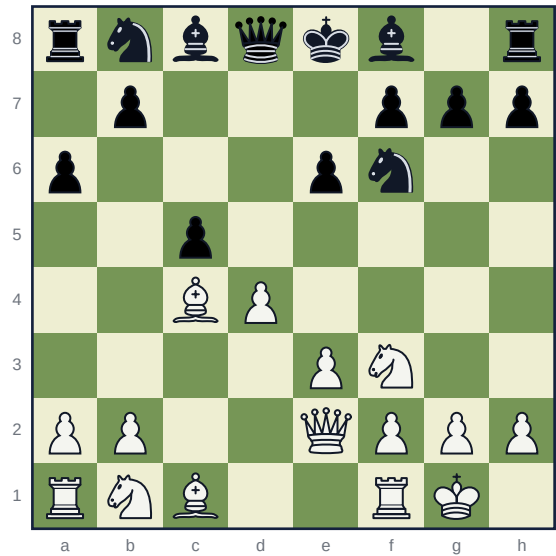
Queen's Gambit Accepted spine

POSITION TRIGGER

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4: Black releases the center and temporarily wins the c-pawn.

Your anchor line

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 e6 5. Bxc4 c5 6. O-O a6 7. Qe2



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

White does not need a pawn-rescue operation. Nf3 develops, e3 opens the bishop, and Bxc4 restores material while gaining central influence. Qe2 supports e4 and prepares Rd1 after castling. Black's free development and ...c5 challenge mean the opening is strategically sound; White's advantage is easier central space, not a trapped pawn by force.

White's plan

- Recover c4 with Bxc4 after e3, then castle.
- Prepare e4 with Qe2 and Rd1 when Black cannot liquidate it immediately.
- Against ...b5, use a4 to undermine only after checking ...Bb7 and open-file tactics.

What Black is trying to do

- ...c5 attacks d4 and frees the queenside bishop.
- ...a6 and ...b5 gain space and tempo against Bxc4.
- ...b5 followed by ...Bb7 puts pressure on e4 and the long diagonal.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
3...Nf6	4.e3 and recover with Bxc4.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
3...a6	4.e3 b5 5.a4 undermines before the pawn chain stabilizes.
4...e6	5.Bxc4; then castle and prepare e4.
4...c5	5.Bxc4 e6 6.O-O; accept an active, open center.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Do not play 3.e4 without preparation in this repertoire. The simple Nf3/e3 sequence reduces tactical burden and reaches the same strategic goals.

MEMORY HOOK

Develop, open the bishop, recover, then build e4.

CHAPTER 02

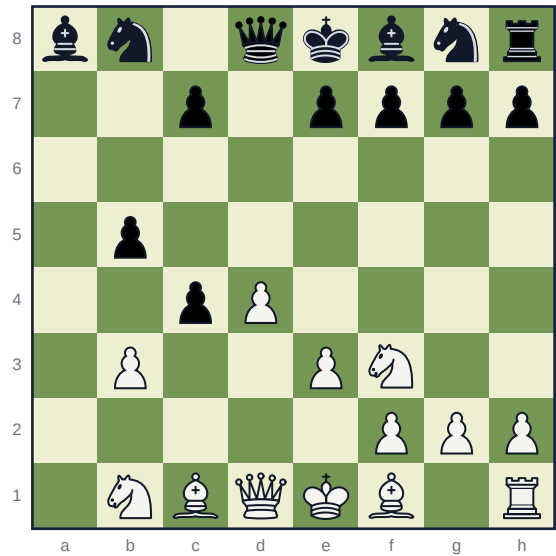
QGA queenside expansion

POSITION TRIGGER

Black supports the c4 pawn with ...a6 and ...b5 before White recovers it.

Your anchor line

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 a6 4. e3 b5 5. a4 Bb7 6. axb5 axb5 7. Rxa8 Bxa8 8. b3



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The move a4 attacks the pawn chain's base before ...Bb7 and ...e6 consolidate. Exchanges open the a-file and make Black spend tempi recapturing. White then uses b3 or Be2 to recover c4 while continuing development. The extra pawn is less important than keeping Black's queenside from becoming a permanent space advantage.

White's plan

- Strike the base with a4 before Black completes ...e6 and ...Nf6.
- Use b3 to challenge c4 when it also develops the c1 bishop after bxc4.
- Keep the king safe; open a- and b-files can create counterplay for both sides.

What Black is trying to do

- ...Bb7 develops with pressure on g2/e4 and supports the queenside pawns.
- ...e6 consolidates c4 and prepares ...Nf6.
- ...b4 can chase Nc3 if White develops the knight carelessly before undermining.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
3...a6	4.e3, inviting ...b5 only when 5.a4 is ready.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
4...b5	5.a4 attacks the chain before consolidation.
5...Bb7	6.axb5 axb5 7.Rxa8; simplify the queenside structure.
...e6	Use b3 or Be2 and castle; pawn recovery should aid development.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Do not chase c4 with queen moves that neglect development. The queenside pawns become targets only if White can mobilize pieces behind the pawn breaks.

MEMORY HOOK

Undermine the base, open the file, recover through development.

CHAPTER 03

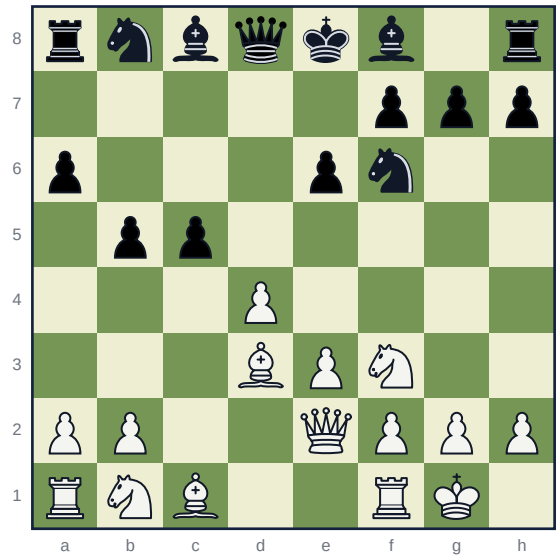
QGA with early ...c5 or ...Bg4

POSITION TRIGGER

Black chooses immediate central activity or pins Nf3 before completing ...e6.

Your anchor line

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 c5 5. Bxc4 e6 6. O-O a6 7. Qe2 b5 8. Bd3



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The early ...c5 is principled: Black returns the pawn to achieve free development. White accepts the open position, castles, and supports e4. Against ...Bg4, Qb3 can pressure b7, but simple Be2 is adequate when tactics are unclear. White should value coordination over preserving a small opening edge.

White's plan

- Castle before pushing e4 in an open center.
- Retreat Bd3 after ...b5, keeping pressure on h7 and support for e4.
- Against a pin, use Be2 or Qb3 according to whether b7 is genuinely vulnerable.

What Black is trying to do

- ...c5 liquidates White's spatial edge and activates the c8 bishop.
- ...Bg4 may provoke a weakening g-pawn recapture or slow e4.
- ...b5 gains tempo against the recovered bishop and creates queenside space.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
4...c5	5.Bxc4 e6 6.O-O; meet activity with development.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
4...Bg4	5.Bxc4 e6 6.Qb3 if b7 pressure is safe; otherwise Be2.
...b5	Retreat Bd3 and use a4 only after castling.
...Nc6	Complete development and prepare Rd1/e4; do not defend d4 passively.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

In open QGA positions, losing a tempo to save the bishop or queen can matter more than a static pawn weakness. Keep moves multi-purpose.

MEMORY HOOK

Open center means castle first and make every move develop or support e4.

CHAPTER 04

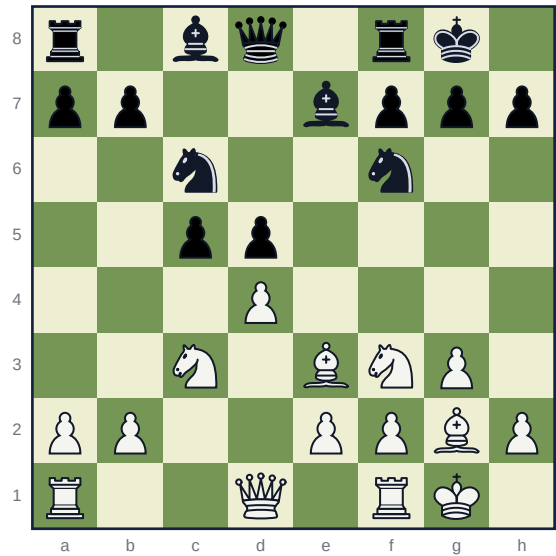
Tarrasch Defense

POSITION TRIGGER

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5: Black immediately attacks d4 and accepts an isolated-pawn possibility.

Your anchor line

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 c5 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 Nc6 6. g3 Nf6 7. Bg2 Be7 8. O-O O-O 9. Be3



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The fianchetto puts long-term pressure on d5 while White develops safely. Black's isolated queen pawn gives space and active-piece squares, especially e4 and c4. White blockades only after neutralizing activity; premature pawn hunting can be punished by ...d4 or ...cxd4 with open lines. Be3 supports d4, develops, and helps connect rooks.

White's plan

- Fianchetto Bg2 and castle; pressure d5 from a distance.
- Control the d4 blockade square and prevent ...d4 under favorable conditions.
- Exchange active pieces, especially those using e4/c4, before attacking the pawn.

What Black is trying to do

- ...d4 can gain space and free pieces if White loses control of the blockade.
- ...cxd4 can create open files and temporary initiative.
- ...Re8, ...Bf8, and ...Bg4 place pieces actively around the isolated pawn.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
3...c5	4.cxd5 establishes the IQP target.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
4...exd5	5.Nf3 Nc6 6.g3 and fianchetto.
...cxd4	Nxd4 when it keeps pieces active; Qxd4 only if queen tempi are harmless.
...d4	Challenge or blockade immediately; do not let the pawn advance with tempo.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

An isolated pawn is weak only when it can be blockaded and attacked. During development it is often an attacking asset.

MEMORY HOOK

First restrain d4, then exchange activity, only then attack d5.

CHAPTER 05

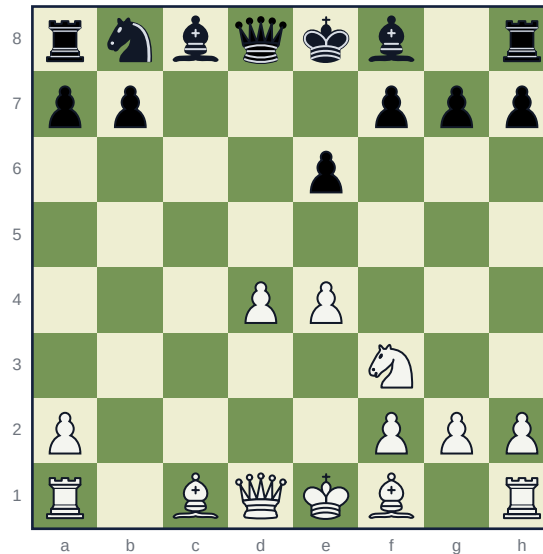
Semi-Tarrasch and knight recapture

POSITION TRIGGER

Black recaptures on d5 with a knight, avoiding an immediate isolated d-pawn.

Your anchor line

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 Nxd5 5. e4 Nxc3 6. bxc3 c5 7. Nf3 cxd4 8. cxd4



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

White gains a broad center and often accepts an isolated d-pawn or hanging pawns after exchanges. The lead in space matters only if White develops rapidly. e4 attacks the centralized knight and claims territory; bxc3 rebuilds the center and opens the b-file. Black aims to attack d4 and use the c-file, so White should seek e5 or d5 when development supports it.

White's plan

- Use e4 to gain space and tempo against Nxd5.
- Develop Nf3, Bd3 or Be2, and castle before pushing the center again.
- Advance e5 or d5 when it gains a square or opens an attack, not merely to avoid a pawn target.

What Black is trying to do

- ...c5 attacks the center before White consolidates.
- ...Bb4 may pin Nc3 or increase pressure on e4.
- ...Nc6 and ...Be7 create rapid pressure on d4.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
4...Nxd5	5.e4. Gain space and force the knight to decide.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
5...Nxc3	6.bxc3 builds a broad center and opens the b-file.
6...c5	7.Nf3. Development supports the center.
...Bb4	Use Bd2 or Qd3 according to whether exchanging the bishop improves your structure.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Do not defend d4 with slow pieces until every pawn is tied down. A mobile center must be used before it becomes a static target.

MEMORY HOOK

Knight recapture gives space: e4, develop fast, then advance at the right moment.

CHAPTER 06

Chigorin Defense

POSITION TRIGGER

1.d4 d5 2.c4 Nc6: Black develops the knight in front of the c-pawn and pressures d4.

Your anchor line

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nc6 3. Nf3 Bg4 4. cxd5 Bxf3 5. gxf3 Qxd5 6. e3 e5 7. Nc3 Bb4 8. Bd2



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

White accepts doubled f-pawns in return for the bishop pair and a strong center. The open g-file can become an attacking asset after the king chooses safety. The position is concrete: Black's queen and bishop develop actively, so White must finish Nc3 and Bd2 before expanding. If the center simplifies, the bishop pair and extra central control often matter more than the cosmetic pawn damage.

White's plan

- Use e3 and Nc3 to chase the queen and build the center.
- Develop Bd2 and decide whether castling queenside or keeping the king central is safer.
- Use the g-file only after king safety and central control are settled.

What Black is trying to do

- ...e5 strikes immediately while White's structure is unsettled.
- ...Bb4 pins Nc3 and increases pressure on d4/e1.
- The queen on d5 may attack d4 and a2 while gaining tempi.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
2...Nc6	3.Nf3 develops and protects d4.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
3...Bg4	4.cxd5 reduces Black's central foothold.
4...Bxf3	5.gxf3 accepts structure for bishop pair and center.
...e5	Develop with Nc3 and meet the central strike before using the open g-file.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Doubled pawns are not automatically weak. Here they support e4, open the g-file, and accompany the bishop pair; Black's activity is the immediate danger.

MEMORY HOOK

Accept the structure, build e3-Nc3-Bd2, and neutralize the queen's activity.

CHAPTER 07

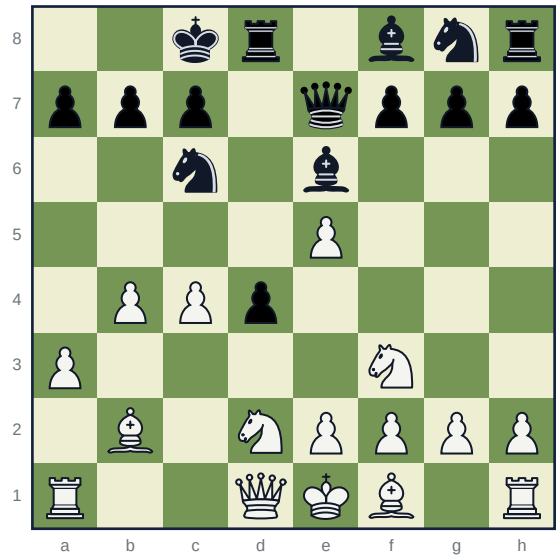
Albin Countergambit

POSITION TRIGGER

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e5: Black offers a pawn to drive a wedge to d4.

Your anchor line

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. a3 Be6 6. Nbd2 Qe7 7. b4 O-O-O 8. Bb2



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

White accepts the pawn but treats Black's d4 pawn as the strategic problem. Nf3 blocks queen checks and attacks d4; a3 prevents ...Bb4+ and prepares b4 to support the extra e5 pawn while gaining queenside space. Nbd2 develops without allowing tactics on c3. Black's compensation is rapid development and pressure on e5, so White must avoid greedy pawn defense.

White's plan

- Blockade d4 with pieces and prepare to attack it after development.
- Use a3 to remove ...Bb4+ and b4 to gain space when the center is secure.
- Return the extra pawn if doing so completes development or dissolves Black's initiative.

What Black is trying to do

- ...Nc6 and ...Be6 develop rapidly against e5 and c4.
- ...Qe7 and long castling create immediate pressure before White castles.
- The Lasker trap themes punish careless e3 or bishop development when the d-pawn can advance.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
2...e5	3.dxe5 accepts the challenge.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
3...d4	4.Nf3. Block checks and attack the advanced pawn.
4...Nc6	5.a3 prevents ...Bb4+ before b4/Nbd2.
...Be6	Nbd2 and b4; keep the queen's diagonal and d4 tactics under observation.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Never play e3 automatically while the d4 pawn controls e3 and tactical sacrifices can open Bb4+. Develop Nf3 and a3 first.

MEMORY HOOK

Block d4, stop ...Bb4+, develop, and gladly return material for safety.

CHAPTER 08

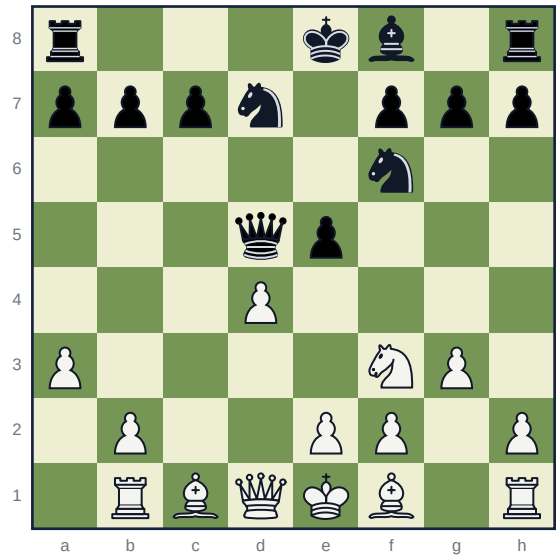
Baltic, Marshall, and other early deviations

POSITION TRIGGER

Black develops Bf5 or Nf6 before choosing ...e6 or ...c6, or uses an unusual second move.

Your anchor line

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Bf5 3. cxd5 Bxb1 4. Rxb1 Qxd5 5. Nf3 Nf6 6. a3 Nbd7 7. g3 e5



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

Against the Baltic ...Bf5, cxd5 exploits Black's temporarily loose center. The bishop may take b1, but White's rook recapture opens the b-file and keeps the bishop pair. Against the Marshall 2...Nf6, cxd5 makes the knight recapture and e4 gains space. Rare systems are handled by the same priorities: challenge the unsupported center, develop with tempo, and avoid hunting the queen unless development benefits.

White's plan

- Exploit an undefended d5 point with cxd5 when Black's development does not support the recapture comfortably.
- Use e4 to gain space against an early Nxd5.
- Develop Nf3, a3, and g3 while the black queen spends time in the center.

What Black is trying to do

- Early ...Bf5 may exchange on b1 and use ...e5 for activity.
- Early ...Nf6 may recapture d5 but loses time to e4.
- Queen activity on d5 can create checks and pressure if White expands too quickly.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
2...Bf5	3.cxd5 challenges d5 immediately.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
3...Bxb1	4.Rxb1. Accept the bishop pair and open b-file.
2...Nf6	3.cxd5 Nxd5 4.e4 attacks the knight and claims the center.
2...e6 then ...f5	Use the Dutch/Stonewall chapter rather than forcing a QGD plan.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Rare does not mean harmless, but it does mean study should remain proportional. Learn the tactical point and one development scheme, then return to calculation.

MEMORY HOOK

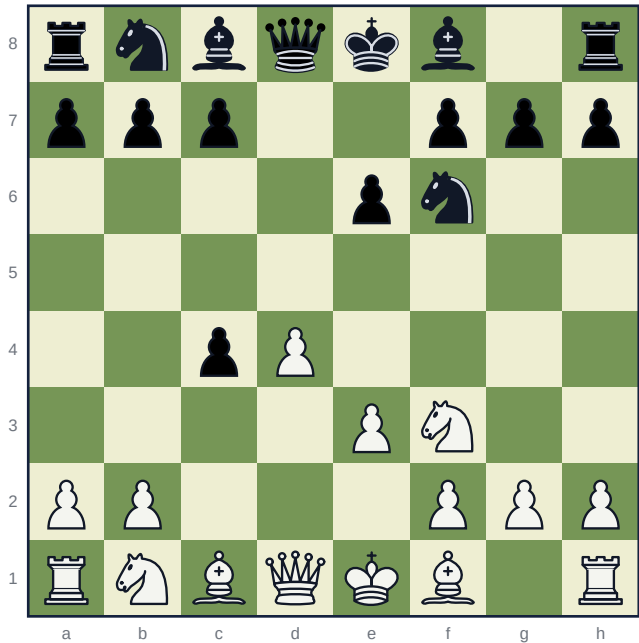
Loose d5: exchange; early knight recapture: e4; early queen: develop with tempo.

Repertoire Test

For every position, name the opening branch, state your strategic objective, and choose a move. The answer is not only a move: it is a move attached to a reason.

TEST 01 | QGA recovery

How should White recover the pawn, and what central plan follows?



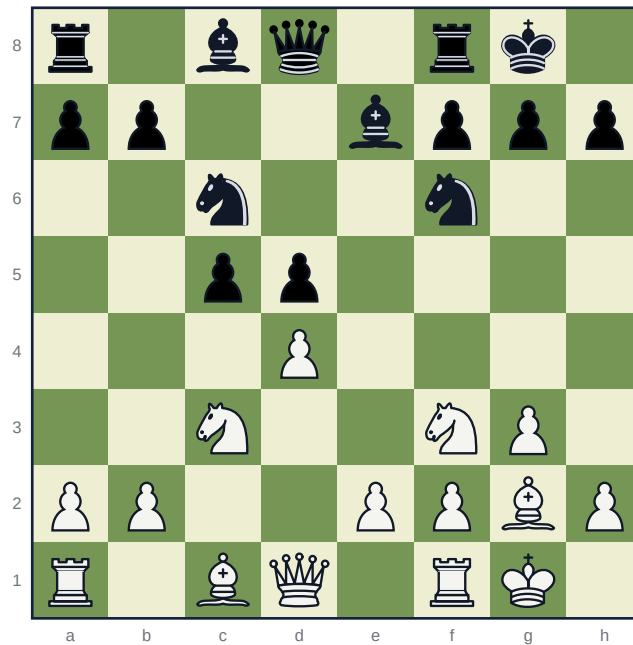
Position reached by: 1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 e6

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

TEST 02 | IQP discipline

What is White's priority before attacking d5?



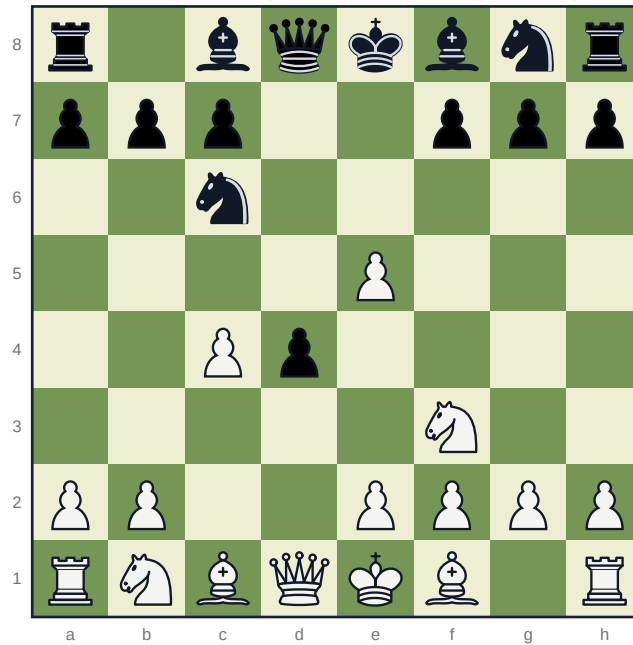
Position reached by: 1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 c5 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 Nc6 6. g3 Nf6 7. Bg2 Be7 8. O-O O-O

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

TEST 03 | Albin safety

Which quiet move removes a major tactical theme before White builds the queenside?



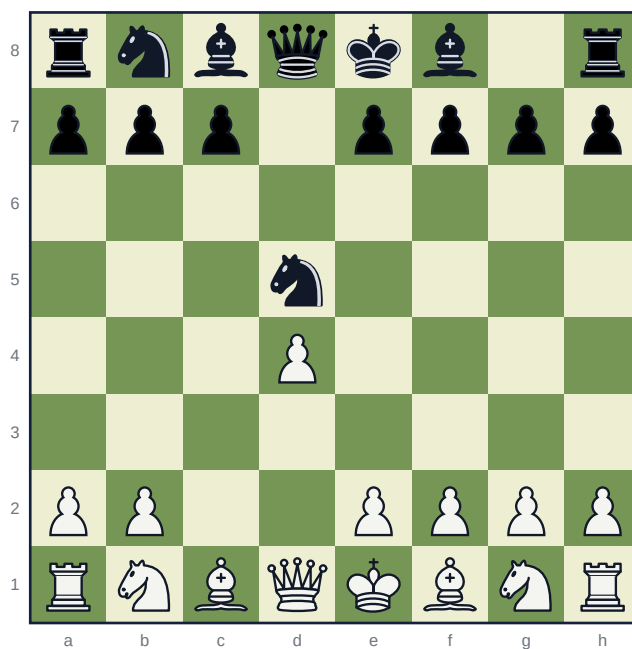
Position reached by: 1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

TEST 04 | Rare but concrete

Which central move uses the knight's exposed position, and what is the strategic gain?



Position reached by: 1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nf6 3. cxd5 Nxd5

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

Repertoire Test - Answers

TEST 01 | QGA recovery

Play 5.Bxc4, then castle. Qe2 and Rd1 support e4. The recovery is strong because it is also development.

TEST 02 | IQP discipline

Restrain ...d4 and neutralize Black's active pieces. Use Be3, Rc1, and sometimes dxc5. Only attack d5 after its dynamic support has been reduced.

TEST 03 | Albin safety

Play 5.a3, preventing ...Bb4+. Then use Nbd2 and b4. Returning the extra pawn is acceptable if it extinguishes Black's initiative.

TEST 04 | Rare but concrete

Play 4.e4, gaining space and forcing the knight to move again. Develop quickly afterward because an expanded center becomes a target if White spends more tempi on pawns.

One-Page Recall Card

Cover the right column. Read the trigger and say the memory hook. Then cover the left column and reconstruct which position produces that hook.

1.d4 d5 2.c4 dxc4: Black releases the center and temporarily wins the c-pawn.	Develop, open the bishop, recover, then build e4.
Black supports the c4 pawn with ...a6 and ...b5 before White recovers it.	Undermine the base, open the file, recover through development.
Black chooses immediate central activity or pins Nf3 before completing ...e6.	Open center means castle first and make every move develop or support e4.
1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5: Black immediately attacks d4 and accepts an isolated-pawn possibility.	First restrain d4, then exchange activity, only then attack d5.
Black recaptures on d5 with a knight, avoiding an immediate isolated d-pawn.	Knight recapture gives space: e4, develop fast, then advance at the right moment.
1.d4 d5 2.c4 Nc6: Black develops the knight in front of the c-pawn and pressures d4.	Accept the structure, build e3-Nc3-Bd2, and neutralize the queen's activity.
1.d4 d5 2.c4 e5: Black offers a pawn to drive a wedge to d4.	Block d4, stop ...Bb4+, develop, and gladly return material for safety.
Black develops Bf5 or Nf6 before choosing ...e6 or ...c6, or uses an unusual second move.	Loose d5: exchange; early knight recapture: e4; early queen: develop with tempo.

SPACED REVIEW

Review today, tomorrow, after three days, after one week, and after one month. A chapter graduates only when you can reconstruct its anchor line and explain its plan without looking.

GAME TRANSFER

After every serious game, locate the first position where your memory ended. Study from that exact fork. This turns the repertoire into a living system while keeping the PDFs as the stable foundation.